

photograph can reveal a company badge, vehicle registration, school uniform, apartment view, local shop, gym logo, conference lanyard or reflection in a window. A birthday photograph may expose relatives and dates. A desk photograph may reveal documents, delivery labels or a computer username.

Download copies of profile images you have reused and run reverse-image searches through reputable search services. The aim is to discover where the same image appears, not to upload private family photographs indiscriminately. Record duplicate profiles and unauthorised copies.



Inspect public photographs at full resolution. Zoom into backgrounds and read visible text. Check whether friends have tagged or named you. Review album visibility, captions, comments and location labels. Remember that removing a tag may stop the photograph appearing prominently on your profile without removing the original upload.

Metadata is another layer. Some files can contain information about the device, creation time, editing software or location. Social platforms may strip some metadata during upload, but you should not rely on this universally. Preserve original files when evidence matters; create cleaned copies for public sharing rather than destroying originals.

Step 4: Find forgotten accounts

Email is often the best account ledger you already possess. Search each inbox for phrases such as:

- “welcome”
- “verify your email”
- “confirm your account”
- “password reset”
- “your receipt”
- “subscription”
- “new login”
- “terms of service”

Search by year to uncover older registrations. Also inspect password managers and browser-saved passwords, but treat those lists as clues rather than proof that an account still exists.

Look through app-store purchase histories and installed-app libraries for services you once used.

For every discovered account, record the service, username, attached email, attached phone number, recovery method, whether the profile is public and whether you still need it. Do not test old passwords across multiple sites. Use the official password-reset or account-recovery process instead.

Data-export tools can reveal information that ordinary profile pages hide. Google Takeout lets users select data from Google products and create an archive. Facebook and Instagram provide export controls through Accounts Centre, while LinkedIn allows members to request a copy of account data from its Data Privacy settings. These exports may contain searches, messages, connections, advertising interests, uploaded contacts or historical profile information, depending on the service and selected archive.

Exports are sensitive. Download them only to a secured device, inspect them offline where practical and remove unnecessary copies after the audit. An export creates another collection of your personal data; it does not automatically delete anything from the service.

Step 5: Inspect what major accounts remember

Start with accounts that connect many parts of your life. In Google My Activity, users can review and delete saved activity and filter records by date or product. Google also provides controls for activity settings and, for some categories, automatic deletion. Treat deletion and collection settings as separate tasks: deleting old records does not necessarily stop new records from being saved.

For a Microsoft account, the privacy dashboard can display and clear supported categories of cloud-associated activity and provide access to privacy settings. The available categories depend on the products, account configuration and region.

On Apple devices, App Privacy Report can show how applications use granted permissions and display network activity.

